

August 12, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Lakendra Roberts (MRN MUSC4738973), Claim MUSC-20260407-4D58-2

Patient	Lakendra Roberts (DOB 1962-07-26)
MRN	MUSC4738973
Member ID / Group	CIG406449781 / GRP-50704
Claim number	MUSC-20260407-4D58-2
Date of service	2026-04-07
Procedure billed	CPT 99284 — Emergency department visit, moderate-to-high severity
Primary diagnosis	J06.9 — Acute upper respiratory infection, unspecified
Denied amount	\$3,653.80
Denial code	CARC 96 / RARC N130 — Non-covered charge(s).
Appeal deadline	2026-10-28

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health is submitting this first-level appeal on behalf of patient Lakendra Roberts (MRN: MUSC8650384, Member ID: CIG406449781, Group: GRP-50704) regarding the denial of Claim MUSC-20260407-4D58-2 for services rendered on April 7, 2026, at MUSC Health University Medical Center. Cigna Healthcare denied the claim in full — billed charges of \$3,653.80 — citing CARC 96 (Non-covered charge(s)) and RARC N130, with the payer remark stating: "Service is excluded under the member's plan benefit document." MUSC Health respectfully disputes this determination. The service at issue — CPT 99284, an emergency department evaluation and management visit of moderate-to-high severity — is a standard, widely covered benefit under commercial health plans, and the denial as stated does not withstand clinical or contractual scrutiny.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Ms. Roberts is a 64-year-old female with a documented history of complex, active chronic conditions including chronic kidney disease, diabetic renal disease, hyperglycemia, prediabetes, metabolic syndrome, and anemia. She is maintained on long-term insulin therapy (Humulin 70/30) and oral agents including Metformin and Hydrochlorothiazide. Her most recently recorded estimated glomerular filtration rate reflects significantly reduced kidney function, and her microalbumin-to-creatinine ratio has been persistently elevated across multiple measurements, indicating ongoing renal compromise. On April 7, 2026, Ms. Roberts presented to the MUSC Health University Medical Center Emergency Department, where she was evaluated by Elena V. Castellanos, MD (NPI 1881726354). The encounter was classified as an emergency visit with a primary diagnosis of acute upper respiratory infection (J06.9) and a secondary diagnosis coded to R69, which in the context of this patient's active conditions — including hyperglycemia and metabolic syndrome — reflects the complexity of her presentation. Given her underlying renal and metabolic disease burden, an acute infectious illness in this patient carries materially elevated clinical risk and appropriately warrants emergency-level evaluation.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

Cigna's denial categorizes CPT 99284 as a non-covered service excluded under the member's plan benefit document. However, emergency department evaluation and management services are among the most universally covered benefits under commercial health insurance, including Cigna Healthcare Choice Plus plans, and are specifically protected under longstanding federal and state prompt-access and coverage standards. MUSC Health requests that Cigna identify with specificity the plan exclusion language upon which this denial is based, as the denial notice itself provides no such citation beyond a general reference to the benefit document.

Furthermore, CPT 99284 was selected in accordance with the documented complexity of the encounter. Ms. Roberts's acute presentation must be evaluated in the context of her active chronic conditions, which include insulin-dependent diabetes with renal involvement, chronic kidney disease, and anemia — all of which elevate the medical decision-making complexity of any acute illness visit. The assignment of moderate-to-high severity is clinically supported by this patient's comorbidity profile. The claim was submitted correctly with appropriate diagnosis coding, place-of-service code 23, and revenue code 0450, all consistent with an emergency facility encounter.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Cigna Healthcare conduct a full and impartial review of this appeal and overturn the denial of Claim MUSC-20260407-4D58-2. Specifically, we request that Cigna reprocess the claim and remit payment at the contracted allowed amount of \$2,515.40, consistent with the plan's own adjudication of the allowable. In the event Cigna maintains its denial, we request a written explanation identifying the precise exclusion language in the member's benefit document that applies to emergency department evaluation and management services, as well as the clinical or contractual rationale for that determination. This appeal is submitted within the deadline of October 28, 2026, and includes supporting medical records for Cigna's review.

Respectfully submitted,

Angela R. Whitfield, RN, BSN, CPC

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record